So What Happened?

March 27th, 2010 at 11:55 am by **DAVID FRUM** | **202 Comments** | Share

After my dismissal from AEI Thursday, I posted in this space my letter of resignation. I declined television interviews, but I did speak to print journalists about the basic facts, in a way that expressed respect for AEI and its leadership.

I spent most of today flying from Washington to San Francisco and emerged from the plane to a fierce counter-attack, including an especially unpleasant piece from **Charles Murray**.

Let me respond here to some specific issues in this matter.

1) Was the firing political? Obviously I cannot enter into people's minds, and at my termination lunch AEI President Arthur Brooks insisted that politics had nothing to do with the decision. So let's just follow the time line. Waterloo piece is posted Sunday March 22. Wall Street Journal editorial denouncing me appears March 23. Summons to lunch arrives on March 23. At lunch I am told that AEI wishes to terminate my salary, office, benefits, and research assistance. I am however at liberty to continue to consider myself part of the AEI family. I declined that offer and wrote a letter of resignation.

2) Was the firing in response to donor pressure? At lunch, Arthur Brooks explained that AEI was facing a new kind of donor environment, in which donors were becoming much more specific about where they wanted their money to go. Arthur expressed extreme personal distress at having to terminate me. It's possible that those words were pro-forma, and that my own affection for Arthur led me to attach more weight to them than I should have. It's very strange that Charles Murray would denounce me as a liar because I wished to think better of my former boss!

3) Did AEI muzzle healthcare scholars? I fear that in reproducing in print a private conversation from some months ago, Bruce Bartlett made a transmission error. I did not report as fact that scholars were laboring under any restrictions. What I did say was that AEI was punching way below its weight in the healthcare debate. I wondered, not aloud, whether AEI scholars were constrained by fear of offending donors and concluding that might get them into trouble. To repeat: this was something I asked many months ago in private conversation, not something I allege today in public debate.

4) Was I terminated for under-productivity? If you'll believe that, you'll believe anything. In seven years at AEI, I wrote 3 books, over 1000 newspaper and magazine articles, millions of words of work journalism. I have made more TV appearances, delivered more lectures than I even know how to count. (I'll be delivering half dozen such lectures in China in the month of April as a guest of the US Department of State.)

I have written speeches on my own for politicians I admire. I worked pro bono on a presidential nomination campaign. Then, there was the campaign to oppose Harriet Miers nomination. Does AEI seriously suggest that I the person who most made possible the successful campaign to oppose nomination to the Supreme Court because I didn't pick up my small mail often enough? That's what they said to **Politico**.

As for Charles' other suggestions, well, they point in a very different direction than he'd like. I did attend for example the 2009 AEI holiday party accosted by Lynne Cheney for my criticisms of Rush Limbaugh. This year I was not invited at all, despite having obtained for the conference some of its most distinguished international guests.

Charles acknowledges that he himself spends almost zero time on the AEI premises. If that's a firing offense, I'll see him at the soup kitchen.

UPDATE:

Finally, one last thought about my reply to AEI's claims above. If it's required that AEI scholars publish their online work at AEI's own blog, why did Charles Murray post his remarks about on me on the Corner, instead of upon … AEI's own blog?

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AEI's Muzzled Scholars: An Apology and Clarification // Mar 28, 2010 at 4:46 pm

[…] comment on elements of Obama's health plan with which they agreed. Since then David has had this to say about our conversation: Did AEI muzzle healthcare scholars? I fear that in reproducing in […]

chriscurrey // Mar 29, 2010 at 1:27 am

Dear Mr. Frum,

Mr. Frum, I have been reading your columns recently. To be honest, I did not know you had a blog, but I was glad to have discovered it. See, I am an old Republican. I am religious, yet not a fanatic. I am a free-marketer; yet, I believe in the role of the government as a fair overbalancer. I am socially conservative; yet, I believe that my lesbian niece and my gay grandchild should have the full protection of the law and live as free Americans enjoying every aspect of society with no prejudices and/or restrictions. Nowadays, my political and socio-economic profile would make me a Marxist, not a Republican.

I grew up in an era where W.F. Buckley fought the John Birch society and kicked them out of the Republican Party. I grew up with Nixon as President for the first time for –Eisenhower. In 1956, he ran a campaign of dignity. A campaign that acknowledged that there are certain projects better suited to be handled by the government. Sad, business thinks in the short term, as he said. That's the imperative of the market place. I invest and I expect that in a few quarters, I garner the fruits of my investment. Government, on the other hand, has the luxury to wait a few years, maybe decades, for a return on a given investment. As a former businessman, I know that first hand. Am I a Marxist for thinking that? I will come back to this question later.

I witnessed the fight for equal civil rights of the 1960s. And as a proud American, I applauded the passage of the Civil Rights Act and Voting Rights Act, and we became a better country because of them. Those acts made America stronger. Those acts, at their core, represented and still represent all the values upon which the Republican Party was founded. Yet today, our GOP representatives and leaders are ashamed of them. When they talk about them, you feel their discomfort, their clumsiness, and sometimes their shame. That awkwardness is so strong that it crosses the television screen and hits in the face in your living room. Why is that? What happened to this generation of Republicans? We are the party of Abraham Lincoln, and yet we act and behave as if we are the party of Nathan Bedford Forrest.

I did not like Medicaid and Medicare when they were passed. I was opposed to them. Maybe I was too young, too strong, and too ideologically confined. Yet, over the years, I saw how Medicare helped millions of elderly Americans; I saw how Medicare helped my mom in her final years battling emphysema caused by years of smoking. You have to blind to oppose those programs. You have to be blind to wish for the suffering of millions of Americans just because you believe in personal responsibility.

As a businessman, I was torn between my bottom line and providing health coverage for my employees. I knew that if I provided them with that coverage, their productivity increases. I did my best, but the riptide of the health insurance market defeated me. And was a heavy hand. Still, I paid them gimmicky coverage that, deep down, I knew did not provide a comprehensive and adequate coverage, but it was the only coverage I could afford.

I voted for Nixon and for Reagan. Although I did not like the deficit spending of the Reagan administration, I blamed it on and understanding it by the necessities of fighting the Cold War. I liked Reagan—who didn't? Even my Democrat and liberal friends liked and respected him. I voted for Clinton, twice. I thought he was the best socialist-president since IKE. No, I did not make a mistake. Bill Clinton was closer ideologically to Eisenhower and Nixon than Bush I and II could ever be. I thought the Clinton practiced and articulated true Republican ideology in his fiscal discipline, job creation, smart tax cuts, and foreign policy than anyone since IKE.

Then something happened in the 1990s. The leaders of the GOP grew belligerent. They became too religious, almost zealots. They became intolerant. They began searching for the purity of the Republican thought and doctrine. Ideology blinded them. I continued to vote Republican, but with a certain unease. Deep down I knew that a schism happened between the modern Republican Party and the one I grew up with. During the fight over the impeachment of President Clinton, the ugly face of the Republican Party was brought to the surface. Empty rhetoric, ideological intolerance, vengeance, and religious zealotry became the common currency. Suddenly, if you are a pro-choice, you could not be a Republican. If you are pro-civil Rights, you could not be a Republican. It started with minorities; they left the party. Then women; they divorced the GOP and sent it to sleep on the couch. Then, the young folks; they left and are leaving the Republican Party in droves. Then, someone stood up and told my niece and my grandchild that they are not fully Americans–second class Americans– just because they are homosexuals. They wished hell and damnation upon my loved ones just because they are different. Are we led my priests or are we led by rational politicians? Now, we have became the party of the Old Straight White Folks. We should rename the Republican Party the GSWF rather than the GOP.

Recently, since the election of Barrack Obama, common sense has left us completely. We are in the era of craziness. As you said it in one of your previous columns, a deal was there to be made over the health care bill. Instead, this ideological purity blinded us. As LBJ said it, instead of being inside the tent pissing out, we choose to be outside the tent and pissing against the wind, and we got splashed by our own urine, by our own nonsense. Why did we do that? Well, when a political party shrinks its electoral based to below 30% and is composed by one demographic group, all that is left are bunch of zealots. We shrank it by kicking out of the party those who believe that abortion should be legal but limited. We shrank it by kicking out those who believe that an 911 trillion economy, like ours, needs a strong government, not a government that can be drowned in a bathtub. We shrink it when we sanctified Rush Limbaugh, Sean Hannity, and Glenn Beck, and canonized Sarah Palin. These are the leaders of my party nowadays. How did we go from William F. Buckley to Glenn Beck? How did we go from Eisenhower and Nixon to Sarah Palin and Michelle Bachmann? I do not know. What I know, however, that these leaders remind of me the leaders of the Whig Party and they will bring the collapse of the GOP.

I do not recognize myself in the Republican Party anymore. As someone said it before, I did not leave the Republican Party, the Republican Party left me. I have the same ideological position on most of the issues that I had when I voted for IKE, Nixon, Reagan and G.W. Bush in 2000. However, I just cannot trust the reins of our government and nation, of this formidably complicated and complex gigantic machine that is the USA, to the amateurish leadership of the Republican Party.

We are living trough tough times. We are being challenged like I have never seen America being challenged before. China is a formidable foe, and it is out there competing against us on every field and beating on several fronts. While the education budgets are being slashed in every state across the nation, China is doubling and tripling theirs. These are the challenges and challengers that we are facing. And we need our best and brightest to lead us, not a half-term governor or radio/TV talking heads.

Do your best Mr. Frum to foster a new generation of rational Republican. Maybe i am too old and too cynical, but i think the Republican party is in the last stages of agony. If nothing happens, we might win an election or even two, but on the long run we will lose America.

PS: I apologize for the length of post, i needed to vent my frustration.

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